12. Our Need for Food

Can you tell ?

- This girl had become very thin and weak during her illness. After a few days, she recovered and became fit and healthy again. What helped her to recover?

Can you tell ?

- What makes this baby gain height and weight?

Why do we feel hungry ?

Our body must function properly. That is why we need food. Food helps our body to grow. It helps to repair the wear and tear of our body. It also gives us the strength we need to work.

If we don't get enough food, we feel tired. Vigour is lost.

At such a time, we feel very hungry. If we eat a little, we feel better at once.

When we work a lot, our body feels fatigued. It makes us very hungry.

Like us, all living things need food.

Can you tell ?

- Do all living things eat the same kind of food ?
- A cow eats grass. Would a cat live on grass too ?
- A cat loves to eat mice. Does that mean a goat would also like to eat mice ?

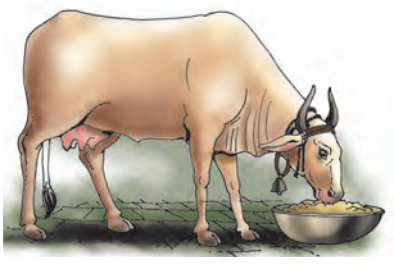
- **To each, their own food.**

New terms :

Oilcake : The fibrous part that is left after extracting oil from seeds such as groundnut, sesame or cottonseed is pressed into slabs. This is called oilcake.

***Ambon* :** A fermented mixture of oilcake, jaggery and coarse particles of grain mixed in water and used as animal feed.

All living things need food. But all living things do not eat the same kind of food.



People who keep cattle feed them grass and hay, and also oilcake and *ambon*. Besides grass and hay, horses are given bengal gram (*harbhara*) soaked in water.

Goats and sheep eat the leaves of various kinds of shrubs besides eating grass.

Cats love to drink milk. But they like mice just as much. They also hunt and eat birds such as sparrows, doves and pigeons.

Dogs may eat chapatis or bhakaris but they prefer to eat meat. People who keep dogs or cats give them meat and fish also.

In forests, animals like the deer, bisons and nilgai eat various kinds of green grass and leaves. If there are crops growing in fields nearby, these animals finish off those crops too.

Wild animals like the tiger and lion live in deep jungles. They hunt other animals and eat their flesh.

Usually, these animals do not hunt in human settlements. But sometimes, when they are starved, they are forced to enter nearby villages. Then, they kill and carry away cattle.

Many times, foxes dare to enter human settlements. But they are not as strong as tigers. They cannot kill cattle. They are mostly content with stealing fowl.

Use your brain power !

- Why do farmers set up a scarecrow and use sling shots when the crops in their field are ready for harvesting ?

We see many differences in what birds eat, too. Many birds eat grain. Farmers grow a variety of cereals and pulses in their fields. As the crop becomes ready for harvesting, the ears become full of grains. Birds in the surroundings come in flocks to feed on them. They can destroy the crop. What is done to prevent such destruction?

It is easily possible for birds to find grains in areas where people live. That is why some birds live in such areas.

Other birds feed on other kinds of food. Hens eat worms. Crows eat the flesh of dead animals. Some birds eat the fruits of trees.

We see many small animals around us. What do they feed upon?

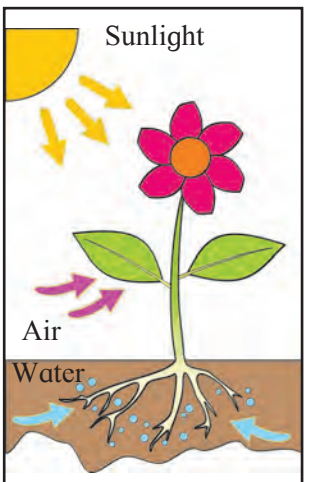
Bedbugs suck people's blood. Ticks suck the blood of cows and buffaloes. House lizards and chameleons eat insects. Caterpillars and some insects nibble at and eat the leaves of plants. Butterflies feed upon the nectar they find in flowers.

Animals eat the food they find in nature. However, they have to wander from place to place in search of food.

Do you know ?

There are many types of mosquitoes. Most of them suck the sap from the plants. Only a few types of mosquitoes suck our blood.

• The food of plants



Plants make their own food!

Plants, too, need food. But they cannot move from place to place in search of food. Then, from where do you think they get their food?

The roots of plants absorb water from the soil. Some substances from the soil are dissolved in this water. This water reaches the leaves of the plants.

There are many tiny pores or openings on the surface of leaves. They are so tiny that we cannot see them with our eyes. Air enters the leaves through these pores.

Thus air and water come together in the leaf. In the presence of sunlight, plants make their own food using the water and air in the leaves.

A plant's food is made in its leaves. Sunlight is necessary for this process.

What we have learnt –

- Living things need food.
- Food gives the body strength to work. It helps the body to grow, and to repair its wear and tear.
- Animals search for ready food in nature and eat it.
- Food of different living things is different. Some animals eat the flesh of other animals, some eat grass and leaves. Some suck the blood of other animals while others eat insects. Some insects feed on the leaves of plants.
- With the help of sunlight, plants prepare their own food.

Always remember –

The entire living world depends on the food prepared by plants.

Exercises

A. What's the solution ?

A potted plant is not growing well. It needs help to grow better.

B. Think and tell.

(1) What major difference between plants and animals did you come to know from this lesson ? Which difference did you know already ?

(2) From the following list of animals, pick out those that eat flesh and those that do not.
Lion, elephant, donkey, wolf, deer, shark.

(3) A tiger eats flesh and so does a vulture. But there is a difference in their feeding habit. What is that difference?

C. Complete the table.

Write what they eat.

Animal	The part of a plant that it eats
Goat	
Butterfly	
Caterpillar	
Mosquito	

D. Answer in brief.

(1) What happens to us if we do not get enough food to eat?

(2) Why do wild animals come to areas where people live?

(3) Why do foxes not hunt a cow even when they enter human settlements?

E. Write an informative passage on one of the following topics :

(1) How plants make their own food.

(2) Why we need food.

(3) The food of pet animals.

Present your information to others in the class.

Activity

Find out : What does the woodpecker eat ? How does the woodpecker obtain its food?